

# How Green Space and Violence are Mediated by Networks: A Case Study in Chicago

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## Introduction

In the spring of 2020, cities across the United States, and the world, went quiet. Parks emptied, community centers closed, bars and cafes shuttered. The places that had hosted the chance encounters that bound neighbors together were no more, and the social fabric of urban life suffered greatly. By no small accident, the US simultaneously saw the largest single-year increase in homicides (Lucas 2021). As Lurigio and Weissman (2022) describe, the isolation and reduced direct encounters caused by the pandemic prevented the peaceful, routine social interactions through which communities ordinarily settle conflicts, confrontations, and disputes. In Chicago, the effect was particularly severe, with the homicide rate jumping 60%—double the national average—from 2019 to 2021 (Savchenko 2025).

However, this wave of violence in Chicago was not evenly distributed. From 2018 through 2020, 63% of the city's homicides and non-fatal shootings occurred within just 15 community areas comprising 24% of the city's population, mostly on the South Side (City of Chicago n.d.). And particularly for Chicago, this statistic is a function of the city's infamous segregation. Chicago has long struggled with the impacts of redlining that have led to perpetual cycles of inequality in underfunded areas, as disinvestment not only affects housing and businesses but also infrastructure such as parks (Willman 2024). The Chicago Region Trees Initiative's 2020 census of the area's urban tree canopy (UTC) found that communities on the wealthy North Side have closer to 30% UTC coverage, while poorer areas on the West and South Sides have, at times, less than half of that (Moore 2025). Correspondingly, those areas are more violent (Andriesen 2023).

The pandemic offered a grim experiment in what happens when social interaction collapses—violence increases. However, it led many to question what structural features of a

neighborhood might sustain social interaction in normal times in order to stave off future crime waves. The conventional explanations, such as poverty, unemployment, and policing, are important yet incomplete, and problematically transfer blame onto individuals rather than the structure of the community they reside in. One relatively under-researched cause is the social organization of a community and the physical structure that engenders it. This paper argues that the presence and quality of public parks and green space, and the social networks they generate, explains geographic variation in urban violence.

Specifically, parks reduce violence primarily by generating neighborhood-level social networks that, in turn, build collective efficacy, informal social control, and shared norms that deter crime. The weak ties and interdependencies between residents who might otherwise never meet lead to a form of informal social control. Well-maintained parks function as structural brokers between otherwise isolated social clusters, lowering the diameter of the neighborhood network and enabling the social control that reduces crime. In community areas where parks are absent or degraded, these bridging ties fail to form, networks remain fragmented, and the collective capacity to regulate violence fails to develop.

I compare three Chicago neighborhoods, Englewood, Washington Park, and Lincoln Park, as a representative spectrum of park quality and violence rates. This design also allows me to track violence while noting differences in income. Park quality is measured by quantitative data such as the amount of trees and vegetation and the existence of community spaces. Qualitative data from surveys that capture perceptions on safety and maintenance will further specify the quality of the park. This research is supported by network diagrams that show side-by-side the variations in physical infrastructure and the weak ties that do or do not grow

between nodes. These cases, while not a perfectly random design, still powerfully prove the importance of bringing network science into the conversation on urban violence.

## **Literature Review**

The causes of violence have been debated by sociologists for generations. Early theoretical frameworks located the causes of deviance in the breakdown of shared norms (Durkheim 1897) or the structural mismatch between culturally prescribed goals and the ability to achieve them (Merton 1938). Later, researchers began to move away from individual pathology to a structural understanding of violence. Shaw and McKay's (1942, as cited in Cullen and Wilcox 2010, 829) social disorganization theory posited that violence is not concentrated because of who lives in a neighborhood, but rather, how that neighborhood is organized. This finding that violence co-occurs with structural social ills offset the biological determinism and rational explanations of crime that were dominant at the time (Kubrin 2009, 226). Socially organized communities have (1) informal surveillance, the casual observation of your neighbors, (2), movement-governing rules, or the avoidance of unsafe areas, and (3) direct intervention of suspicious or unacceptable activities (227). Without the ability of communities to realize their common values or solve common problems, violence increases. Subsequent scholarship has specified these mechanisms of social disorganization, as will be discussed, while other literature has documented that neighborhoods with more parks experience less violence. This paper builds at the intersection of these concepts.

The critical question that followed Shaw and McKay's idea was what, exactly, constitutes this social organization, and which mechanisms link its erosion to violence. Kornhauser (1978, as cited in Cullen and Wilcox 2010, 829) built on this theory, arguing that the aforementioned aspects of social organization foster informal social control, or the scope of collective

intervention that the community directs towards local problems like crime. As Cullen and Wilcox (2010, 829) succinctly describe,

Solidarity, cohesion, and integration or social ties generate informal social control, which ultimately prevents crime. This is why socially organized communities have lower crime rates than socially disorganized communities—they have greater levels of informal social control.

While strong networks and cohesion may be necessary for social control, Sampson, Raudenbush, and Earls (1997) argue that earlier works missed a key factor in the mobilization of residents to actually enact rules on their peers. Their concept of collective efficacy, or the combination of social cohesion among neighbors and their willingness to intervene on behalf of the common good, is the means by which “urban neighborhoods inhibit the occurrence of personal violence” (919). Analyzing surveys from around 8,000 Chicagoans across the city, the authors found that even between neighborhoods with similar poverty levels, the degree to which residents are connected, can build trust, and act collectively when norms are violated, is what separates violent from less violent neighborhoods.

Collective efficacy, however, presupposes that residents across a neighborhood are connected at all. Communities are home to both bonding ties within dense social clusters, and bridging ties across different groups that bring about “social capital” (Putnam 2000, 22-23). The latter are weaker connections that generate a common sense of trust and civic cooperation; the kind of ties that enable the community-wide collective action and informal social control that other scholars theorized. In network terms, weak ties between people from different social

clusters are paradoxically more valuable than strong ties for community-level outcomes (Granovetter 1973, 1373-1375). These connections carry information, norms, and trust across the social divides and geographic constraints that otherwise fragment a neighborhood into isolated pockets without a common moral understanding. Without them, collective efficacy atrophies, and violence concentrates.

Notably, the same dense social in-group networks and informal neighborhood-level social control that inhibits violence, provides the same social capital to offenders, as well. Neighborhood clusters of high network interaction can undermine the regulatory effectiveness of collective efficacy, as those ties constrain the community from exercising social control against those it knows in the name of neighborly kindness (Browning, Feinberg, and Dietz 2004, 510-511). This paradox of social organization also manifested in Weimar Germany, where denser networks of civic associations facilitated faster entry into the Nazi Party (Satyanath, Voigtländer, and Voth 2017, 479). Social capital is not inherently prosocial, but neutrally exists in any community, and the structure and norms a community carries alters the success or failure of their collective action.

A related body of research has documented that neighborhoods with more green space experience less violence. A study of 98 buildings in one of Chicago's public housing developments found that buildings surrounded by trees and vegetation had 56% fewer violent crimes than identical buildings surrounded by barren land (Kuo and Sullivan 2001, 355). The authors argued that vegetation deterred crime both by increasing informal surveillance and by mitigating some of the psychological precursors to violence. Following studies have proven the negative link between vegetation and crime (Wolfe and Mennis 2012; Troy, Grove, and O'Neil-Dunne 2012; Bogar and Beyer 2016). However, these mechanisms work on an

individual-level, and have not adequately addressed the network structure by which parks actively build collective efficacy.

The gap between these two literatures has not been fully fleshed out. The concept of third places—informal public settings distinct from home and work—argues that communities need physical settings that host regular, voluntary, face-to-face interactions among a mix of familiar and unfamiliar community members (Oldenburg [1989] 2023). Here, weak, cross-cluster ties are generated. Kuo et al. (1998) is the first known paper to bridge the gap between network mechanisms like collective efficacy and green space inhibitions on violence. Researchers conducted interviews with 145 residents of another public housing development in Chicago, using ratings of greenness and neighborhood social ties to find that the relationship between levels of vegetation and neighborhood social ties could be mediated by use of common space or stress (832; 840-841). Another study applied Sampson, Raudenbush, and Earls's (1997) measures of collective efficacy to data from the Los Angeles Family and Neighborhood Study (LAFANS) across 63 census tracts, finding that the number of parks within a tract was associated with higher individual reports of collective efficacy (Cohen, Inagami, and Finch 2008, 200-201; 205). Ultimately, greener common spaces attract more people outdoors, increasing opportunities for casual encounters and fostering the development of neighborhood social ties.

However, this mechanism is conditional. Parks only function as bridging infrastructure when residents actually use them, and when the space is perceived as safe, welcoming, and worth returning to. Urban green spaces, when well-maintained and amenity rich, can stimulate social cohesion (Peters, Elands, and Buijs 2010; Jennings and Bamkole 2019). Thus, park quality has to be enough to produce the weak ties on which collective efficacy depends and can inhibit violence. What remains undertheorized is the network mechanism that links collective efficacy

and quality of green spaces. This motivates the comparative case design that follows, measuring not only access to parks but also whether they function as bridging, third places.

### **Social Network Argument**

To comprehensively understand the variation in networks due to green space, and its implications for urban violence, three community areas of Chicago were studied: Englewood, Washington Park, and Lincoln Park, in order of increasing green space quality and decreasing violence. A depiction of a sample network overlaid on a map of each neighborhood is seen in Figures 1, 2, and 3, following the same order as above. Each diagram contains 15 nodes clustered in groups of at least two and at most five. Circles represent individual residents and stars represent parks, while strong ties are black and weak ties are dashed. Strong ties are referred to here as bonds and weak ties as interdependencies as defined by Blokland (2003, 66-67). I theorize that weak, interdependent ties are the substrate of collective efficacy and informal social control that inhibits violence in cities, and effective parks serve as the catalysts. I also expect that because bridging ties lower the diameter of a neighborhood's network, those with more and higher-quality parks will sustain higher levels of collective efficacy.

The causal mechanism between green space and violence is argued to be network density and collective efficacy. First, parks function as third places, hosting repeated, voluntary, low-stakes encounters between residents who would otherwise remain in separate clusters. In other words, parks act as brokering nodes. These encounters generate weak, bridging interdependencies. Specifically, parks with inclusive programming are effective brokers between isolated generations and clusters, avoiding the aforementioned paradox. Finally, as the network diameter contracts, the social contagions of norms and information travel faster, and collective efficacy manifests itself. For example, in Figure 1 (Englewood), a norm violation on one block

may never reach residents a few blocks away. In Figure 3, it likely would. Washington Park (Figure 2), home to a single large, manicured park, sits between the two. Two residents of Englewood who live in adjacent buildings may never meet, while two Lincoln Park neighbors are brought together weekly at the farmers market. This is directly related to the existence, or lack thereof, of both weak ties and brokering parks themselves.

*Figure 1. Englewood.*

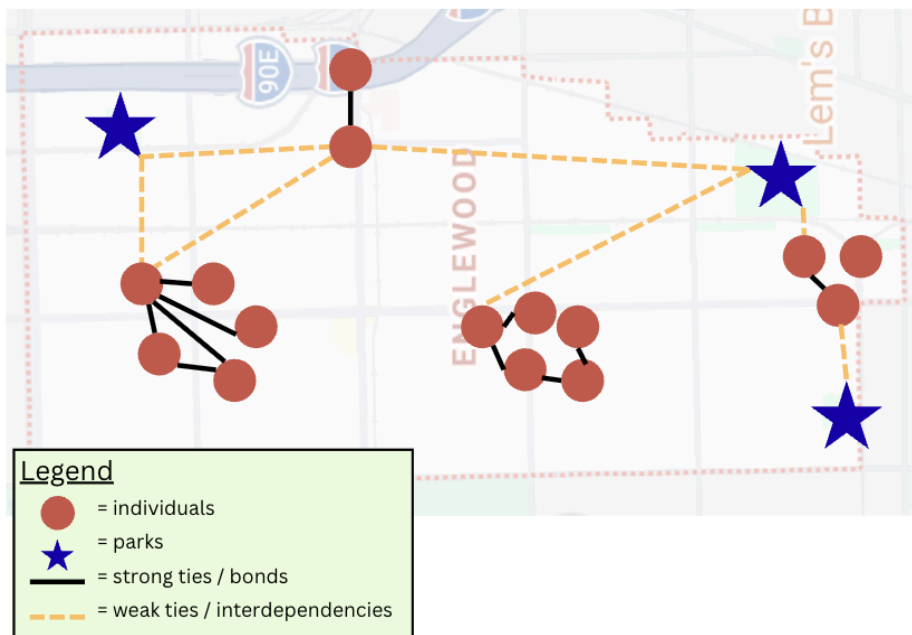


Figure 2. Washington Park.

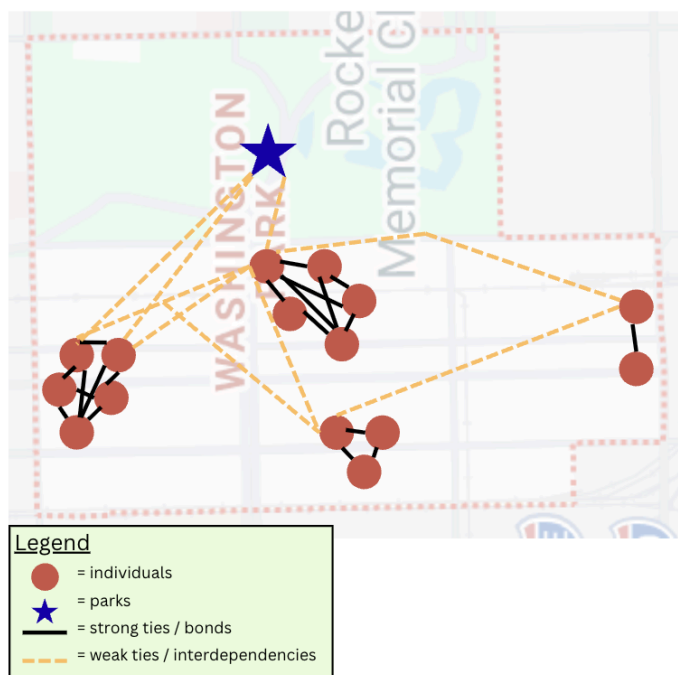
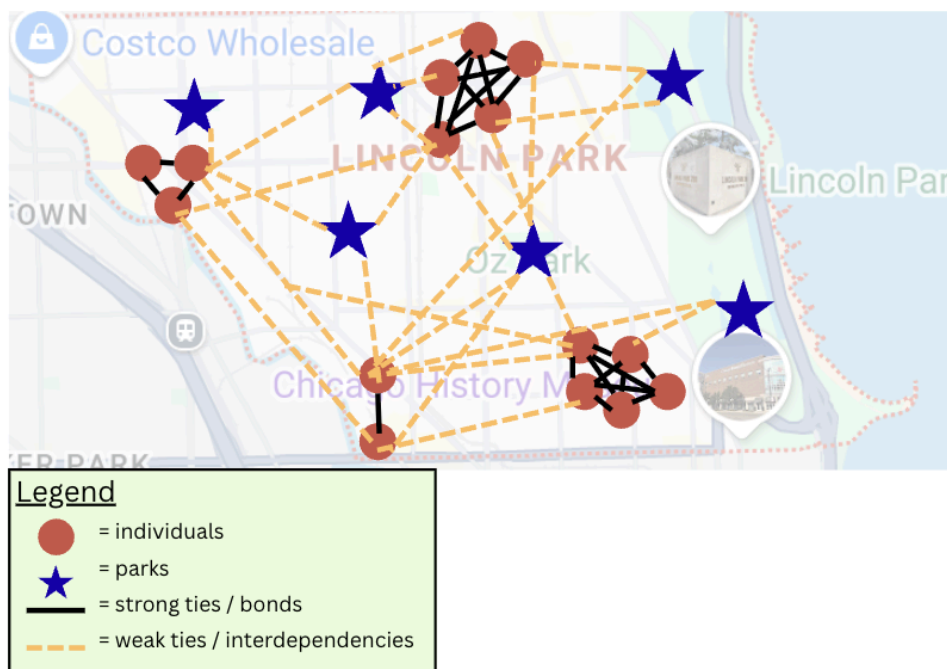


Figure 3. Lincoln Park.



## Methods

I test my hypotheses using publicly available data on all three of the community areas. Violence is measured using data from the City of Chicago (City), specifically counts of violent crime for each neighborhood. “Violent crime” includes homicides, robberies, sexual assaults, and aggravated assaults, to name a few, and property crime is not included. Park presence and distribution are mapped using the Chicago Park District inventory, and park quality is wholly assessed using the Trust for Public Land’s ParkScore measures, Chicago Region Trees Initiative (CRTI) canopy data, and future park programming data from the City. Where possible, I supplement these with resident perception data from surveys conducted by the Chicago Metropolitan Agency for Planning (CMAP) and the Project on Human Development in Chicago Neighborhoods (PHDCN).

This design will effectively capture the quality of parks, as seen by residents, and the variation in crime across neighborhoods. Less demonstrated is the networks of weak ties or collective efficacy; however, I infer their presence from physical infrastructure and social outcomes of the neighborhood. I can neither completely rule out the aforementioned covariates like income, race, and historical disinvestment that have plagued Chicago. Ideally, I could study completely random neighborhoods, and gather data on resident perceptions on parks and phone data on park usage, possibly tracking if an encounter at a park led to a weak tie. My design, while not foolproof, nonetheless generates compelling evidence that networks mediate the violence-mitigating function of parks.

## Results

The three community areas vary sharply in terms of violence. In 2025, Chicago’s citywide homicide rate was 14.6 per 100,000 residents (Ballard, Guevara Hernandez, and Lopez

2025). Using CMAP population data, combined with City data on violent crime and homicides, the spectrum of this paper can be illustrated in relation to the city. From April 2025 to April 2026, Washington Park's violent crime rate was 2,212 per 100,000 people and the homicide rate was 30.5. In Englewood, the rates are 2,924 and 65.4, respectively; Lincoln Park's numbers are 226 and 0 for violent crimes and homicides (Chicago Police Department n.d.; CMAP 2025). Ultimately, Englewood's homicide rate is more than 4 times higher than that of the city.

Conventionally, the explanation for this gradient is income. Lincoln Park's median household income of \$137,505 dwarfs both Englewood's (\$29,727) and Washington Park's (\$27,869) (CMAP 2025). Nonetheless, Englewood's violent crime rate is about 32% higher than that of Washington Park, and its homicide rate is more than double. If poverty alone drove crime, it would be expected that both communities face similar levels of violence. While both dangerous, there is a notable gap, which I argue is due to structural differences.

However, the violence gradient does not map neatly onto park presence. In fact, 98% of residents live within a 10-minute walk to a public park, and residents in low-income neighborhoods have access to 16% more park space per person than those in an average Chicago neighborhood and 20% more than high-income ones (Trust for Public Land 2025). Washington Park contains the famous 372-acre Washington Park, designed by Frederick Law Olmsted, whose firm also designed two smaller parks, Hamilton and Sherman, in Englewood. In terms of UTC, Lincoln Park had a coverage of 26% in 2017, followed by Englewood with 25% and Washington Park with 22%—all against a citywide average of 19% (Chicago, Bureau of Forestry 2023). But not all trees are the same. By combining UTC, surface temperature, flood risk, air quality, asthma rates, and low-income, non-English-speaking, minority populations, the CRTI

identifies both Englewood and Washington Park as priority areas that could benefit the most from tree planting.

Clearly, there is a lot of nuance to the relationship between green spaces and violence, and vegetation does not simply draw residents outdoors. The presence of parkland or trees themselves don't activate a community; rather, programming and thoughtful design stimulate connection. Lincoln Park's namesake park, the largest in the city, is home to several community anchors. The Green City Market runs twice a week, and the Lincoln Park Zoo, the Peggy Notebaert Nature Museum, and the Chicago History Museum are situated inside the park, not to mention public courts for baseball, soccer, and beach volleyball. As of April 2026, the neighborhood's parks collectively offer 192 activities across five facilities: 111 at Lincoln Park, 34 at Wrightwood, 19 at Adams, 17 at Oz, and 11 at Trebes, with a rate of 2.83 events per 1,000 residents (Chicago Park District n.d.). These events include jewelry, ballet, barre, teen leadership, and more, reflecting a variety of cross-generational programming that leads to weak ties between clusters.

On the other hand, Englewood and Washington Park have neither the scale nor the consistency of Lincoln Park's programming. Englewood has 63 activities across 3 facilities; Washington Park's namesake park hosts 56 activities. With a similar UTC and park access, Englewood only offers one-third of Lincoln Park's official Chicago Park District programming. Further, Englewood's Hamilton Park, the most network-stimulating with 46 events, also hosts jewelry and sports events, together with 7th Police District Beat meetings, an employment fair, and a talent show (Chicago Park District n.d.). The neighborhood's parks are dominated by sports and civic obligations that tend to be grouped by age. Washington Park's activities include basketball skills, cardio tennis, and family-oriented activities. Per 1,000 people, the area actually

has 4.27 events, but the sheer density and variety of cross-generational activities in Lincoln Park produces the kind of park use that is consistent with weak-tie generation and successful third places—exactly the substrate of collective efficacy.

This asymmetry in programming density is no accident. A 1982 federal civil suit against the Chicago Park District accused it of providing “fewer programs and poorer facilities in Black and Latino neighborhoods” (Graf 2019, para. 5). Subsequent reporting has documented the same pattern. The Friends of the Parks (FOTP), the city’s largest non-profit park advocacy group, published a scathing report in 2018 that illustrated clear inequities in Chicago’s public parks. Chicago Park District Region N4, including community areas next to Lincoln Park, offered almost 3,000 separate activities, while the S2 region, next to Englewood, provided 757 (Friends of the Parks 2018, 62). Correspondingly, the former region is mostly white and Latino and has a low poverty rate and a high life expectancy, while the latter is predominantly black, poor, and home to residents that experience a significantly shorter life expectancy (62, 64). Through a robust classification of Chicago’s public parks, FOTP found that while the Southern regions have 3,833 acres of parkland compared to the North’s 2,475, the South region has the most nature preserve, passive, and unimproved parkland, “leaving residents with fewer spaces for structured recreation” (16).

Ultimately, green spaces in Englewood and Washington Park have had to resort to grassroots events, which often operate in spite of the environment rather than through it, and do not successfully activate the parks as the third spaces they should be. The Resident Association of Greater Englewood hosts “So Fresh Saturdays” at vacant lots around the neighborhood, with local artists performing as residents work to challenge the narrative that their parks are unsafe (Million Experiments n.d.). Separately, the non-profit Think Outside Da Block hosts an annual

Roll N Peace bike ride through Englewood each summer, intentionally designed to change community perceptions of the neighborhood (Hill 2025). Third places work because they host repeated, routine, low-stakes encounters between separate clusters of individuals. A weekly farmers market, or world-class museums, or events for all ages produces this, while annual festivals or grassroots events may not have the pull without the institutional infrastructure the park district provides.

In terms of network activation, Sampson's own book, *Great American City: Chicago and the Enduring Neighborhood Effect* (2012) provides the most concrete measure of collective efficacy. Using two surveys from the PHDCN data (1995 and 2002) linked to geocoded homicide records through 2006, Chicago neighborhoods in the highest quartile of collective efficacy had homicide rates of about 10.4 per 100,000, compared to over 16 per 100,000 in the lowest quartile (Sampson 2012, 174). He also differentiates between collective efficacy (neighborhood watches, afterschool programs) and collective civic events (less spontaneous; non-profits) arguing that both are theoretically important (200). It is not that Washington Park will have less violence because it has a nicer, central park compared to Englewood's variation; rather, the community's organizational life, and thus its informal social control, is less spontaneous.

Today, the Chicago Department of Public Health (CDPH) provides perhaps the most direct, modern measures of collective efficacy in my neighborhoods. First, the CDPH in its annual, self-administered Healthy Chicago Survey (HCS), includes a question that asks whether a resident strongly agrees or agrees that they really feel part of their neighborhood (Chicago Department of Public Health n.d.). This is quite similar to how Sampson, Raudenbush, and Earls (1997) studied trust and social cohesion with a five-item Likert scale, with questions like "this is a close-knit neighborhood" and "people in this neighborhood can be trusted" (920). As predicted,

48.7% of Chicagoans in Lincoln Park, from 2023-2024, said that they felt part of their neighborhood, while that rate is 28.6% and 26.5% for Englewood and Washington Park, respectively (CDPH n.d.). Areas that have higher social cohesion generally have lower rates of violent crime. Between the South Side cases, it may be possible that Englewood's programming, dispersed across three mid-sized facilities, may generate more belonging than Washington Park's single, high-use park.

The CDPH partners with a software company, Metopio, to also score neighborhoods on a composite index called the Social Engagement Index (SEI). This incorporates information about neighborhood resiliency and barriers to social engagement to measure elements of civic engagement and social isolation (CDPH n.d.). Higher values indicate more social engagement. Lincoln Park sits above the citywide average of 75 at 77.5, with Englewood and Washington Park nearly tied at about 61. Given the differing violence rates of the South Side communities, and the identical measure of structural disengagement, the evidence points to dispersed versus concentrated programming as a potential differentiating variable.

An expected alternative explanation is that it is not parks that trigger weak-tie networks that inhibit violence, but rather, long-term structural disinvestment and income are better predictors. Indeed, Lincoln Park's median household income dwarfs both South Side cases, and many would argue that wealthier residents have access to more social networks and institutions that lead to dense, violence-inhibiting networks. Going further, the poorer neighborhoods, as demonstrated by "So Fresh Saturdays", may experience a negative feedback loop. For example, residents avoid unsafe green spaces, programming shuts down, the park goes unmaintained, with its weak ties lost, the park becomes an ineffective third space. This is compounded by the

documented history of deliberate neglect on behalf of the Chicago Park District towards South Side communities, which has clear consequences for the violence and disinvestment they face.

*Table 1. Indicators by community area.*

|                 | Population | Median Income | Violent Crime Rate | Homicide Rate | Park Activities | SEI  |
|-----------------|------------|---------------|--------------------|---------------|-----------------|------|
| Lincoln Park    | 67,831     | \$137,505     | 226                | 0             | 192             | 77.5 |
| Washington Park | 13,111     | \$27,869      | 2,212              | 30.5          | 56              | 61   |
| Englewood       | 21,411     | \$29,727      | 2,924              | 65.4          | 63              | 61   |

*Note.* Violent crime and homicide rates are per 100,000 residents, April 2025-April 2026. Park activities only reflect events hosted by the Chicago Park District. Sources: Chicago Police Department (n.d.); CMAP (2025); Chicago Park District (n.d.); CDPH (n.d).

Using income as an alternative explanation, one would predict that Englewood and Washington Park, two neighborhoods with nearly identical median incomes and similarly high poverty rates, would have similar levels of violence—and yet, that is not the case (Table 1). That said, this design cannot fully rule out income as a confounding factor without counts of bridging-tie generation and collective efficacy. The ideal test would draw on Sampson, Raudenbush and Earls (1997) and Moyer et al. (2019), specifically the neighborhood cluster approach of the former that used geographically contiguous census tracts that were internally homogenous. This would be randomized across the city. By measuring networks of random, clustered neighborhoods, I could control for income and other covariates that likely influence green space quality.

## Conclusion

As society becomes increasingly polarized, Americans yearn for community—and it is upon municipal, state, and federal governments alike to foster this lest their residents turn to violence. Here, the geographic distribution of urban violence was shown to reflect the distribution of parks as institutional third places that, when sustaining repeated, casual encounters, generate weak, interdependent, and cross-generational ties that inhibit violence through collective efficacy and informal social control. The comparison of Englewood, Washington Park, and Lincoln Park indicates that park acreage, canopy coverage, and park access do not track the violence gradient alone. Rather, park programming and overall quality were better predictors of the success that a park has in catalyzing a network.

The argument advanced here travels beyond Chicago. Similar dynamics appear in other cities where large but under-programmed open spaces exist. Recently, the Navy Yard neighborhood of DC has witnessed several “teen takeover” incidents, where groups of juveniles swarm the neighborhood, frequently leading to fights and, sometimes, shootings (Mack 2026). As seen in Chicago, structural variables like historical segregation and income may be at play, and context may shed some light on the issue. However, the situation is unfolding as predicted by this paper, where green spaces without institutional programming and third-space qualities will not sufficiently anchor the neighborhood and lead to positive benefits. The question is not whether to invest in parks, it is whether we are willing to do so adequately: to invest in them as places where neighborhoods are made, or where they fall apart.

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